

Ethics in Psychological Assessments

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This paper will include various discussions concerning ethics within psychological testing and assessments including multicultural and diversity issues. In addition, this paper will cover aspects of how to avoid potential ethical issues within these assessments. A discussion will also cover how a clinician should assess behaviors that are specific to certain cultures and subcultures and identify how these behaviors stem from different cultures. Finally, there will be a discussion on how a client's academic, education, career, personal, and social development impacts the counselor's assessment choice. Throughout the discussions in this paper, section E of the ACA Code of Ethics will be referred to quite frequently as this section provides specific guidelines for providing clinically sound and culturally competent psychological assessments.

Ethical Issues and How to Avoid Them

Psychological assessments are essential tools in clinical, educational, and organizational settings, providing valuable insights into cognitive functioning, personality traits, emotional wellbeing, and behavior (Fleming, 2020). However, psychological assessments must be guided by strict ethical standards to protect individuals' rights and ensure that results are valid, reliable, and appropriately interpreted (Cohen et al., 2022). These guidelines are clearly outlined within the ACA Code of Ethics and should be followed to provide culturally competent, accurate, holistic psychological assessments (ACA, 2014).

Informed Consent

One of the foundational ethical practices not just in assessment and testing but in the counseling profession, is that of informed consent. Clients have the right to decide whether to begin or continue a counseling relationship and must be provided with sufficient information about the counseling process and the counselor. Informed consent is not a one-time event but a

continuous aspect of the counseling process, and counselors are responsible for properly documenting all informed consent discussions throughout the course of the therapeutic relationship (ACA, 2014).

Avoiding an Ethical Issue

Before providing a psychological assessment, a counselor must ensure that their client is informed of their rights, and that they clearly give their consent to participate in the assessment. In a case where the client is unable to give their informed consent, for example if the client is a minor or an incapacitated adult, the counselor must take the necessary steps as outlined in the Code of Ethics. According to the ACA Code of Ethics, when working with minors, individuals with impairments, or others who cannot provide voluntary consent, counselors strive to obtain the client's agreement to participate in services and involve them in the decision-making process as much as is appropriate (2014). Counselors should be mindful of the need to balance clients' ethical rights to make their own choices, their ability to give consent or assent, and the legal rights and responsibilities of parents or family members to protect and make decisions for them (ACA, 2014).

Multicultural and Diversity

All people, regardless of their cultural background, possess multiple identities, such as ethnic, gender, and career-related identities (Leong et al., 2019). Culture shapes the specific nature of these identities and influences which ones are most prominent or easily accessed, ultimately affecting how they influence a person's behavior (Leong et al., 2019). These core cultural differences in identity are connected to a variety of cultural variations in emotions, thinking patterns, and behaviors (Leong et al., 2019). Psychological assessments have historically been developed based on Western, white, middle-class norms (Cohen et al., 2022).

As a result, test results may not accurately reflect the abilities or characteristics of individuals from diverse cultural backgrounds including potential language barriers.

Avoiding an Ethical Issue

There are various multicultural considerations a counselor should consider before providing a psychological assessment. Cultural fairness is a critical ethical issue in psychological testing and assessments. According to the ACA Code of Ethics section E, counselors should carefully choose their assessment tools, especially when those tools were standardized on different populations than the client (2014). Counselors should be aware of how factors such as age, ethnicity, culture, disability, gender, race, language preference, religion, spirituality, sexual orientation, and socioeconomic background can influence how tests are given and interpreted (ACA, 2014). Counselors consider these influences and place test results in context alongside other important information (ACA, 2014). Counselors are to convey information in a manner that is suitable for the client's developmental level and cultural background. They should use clear and simple language that is easy to understand when addressing important topics (ACA, 2014).

Confidentiality and Appropriate Use of Tests and Results

Confidentiality and the responsible use of test results is another fundamental ethical practice of psychological assessments. Counselors should also understand that there are limits to confidentiality, which are clearly outlined in the Code of Ethics. This includes sharing information regarding assessment results and knowing when to report results and who they should report the results to. Section E states that counselors are also accountable for ensuring that assessment tools are applied, scored, interpreted, and used correctly in relation to the client's

needs, as well as their cultural background, whether they perform these tasks themselves or rely on technology or external services (ACA, 2014).

Avoiding an Ethical Issue

Counselors should explain the necessary limits to confidentiality when working with clients who are mandated to receive counseling. They also clarify, before counseling begins, what specific information may be shared and with whom it will be disclosed (ACA, 2014). Counselors are to be mindful and sensitive as to how different cultures view confidentiality and privacy (ACA, 2014). In addition, they should honor diverse perspectives on sharing personal information and engage in ongoing conversations with clients about what information may be shared, when it can be shared, and with whom (ACA, 2014). Section E of the Code of Ethics states that when reporting assessment results, counselors are to consider the client's cultural and personal background, their ability to understand the results, and how the results may affect them individually (ACA, 2014). Counselors should also mention any concerns about the accuracy or reliability of the results that may arise from the testing conditions or the use of norms that may not be appropriate for the individual assessed (ACA, 2014).

Assessing Behaviors that Stem from Cultures and Subcultures

When assessing behaviors influenced by a client's culture or subculture, counselors must approach the process with cultural humility, awareness, and sensitivity (Alegria et al., 2010). There may be behaviors that may seem unusual, problematic, or even symptomatic in one cultural context may be entirely normative, valued, or adaptive in another (Alegria et al., 2010). Therefore, to provide ethical and effective psychological assessments, it requires a thorough understanding how cultural beliefs, values, norms, and experiences shape an individual's behavior (Cohen et al., 2022).

Cultural Self-Awareness

An important first step in assessing culturally specific behaviors is to increase their self-awareness about their cultural beliefs and values. Encouraging greater self-awareness helps therapists become more effective in their work (Pereira et al., 2024). Research has shown that therapists who are more in tune with their own thoughts and emotions tend to be perceived as more effective during sessions. Highly effective therapists often excel in different areas and have a clear understanding of both their strengths and their limitations, including their beliefs and attitudes regarding the assessment of multicultural behaviors (Pereira et al., 2024).

Culturally Appropriate Assessment Tools

It is essential to ensure that assessments are equitable and free from bias for all clients. Factors such as socioeconomic status, culture, and language can affect test results, so counselors must work to reduce these influences to accurately reflect a client's behavior (Cadime & Mendes, 2024). This involves continuously reviewing and assessing testing tools and procedures to identify and correct any potential sources of bias, errors, or limitations (Cadime & Mendes, 2024). Section E in the ACA Code of Ethics states that counselors should thoughtfully evaluate validity, reliability, psychometric limitations, culture appropriateness, and suitability of assessment tools when choosing which ones to use (ACA, 2014). Whenever possible, they incorporate multiple types of assessments, data sources, or instruments to support their conclusions, diagnoses, or recommendations (ACA, 2014).

Cultural Formulation Interview

While assessing behavior that stems from cultures or subcultures, a counselor might use a cultural formulation interview. The Cultural Formulation Interview (CFI) is designed to enhance culturally responsive diagnosis and treatment by centering the client's viewpoint and social

context (Jarvis et al., 2020). Early research suggests that the CFI can strengthen clinical communication by improving the relationship between counselor and client, enabling the counselor to gather culturally relevant information quickly, uncovering the client's beliefs about the origins of their behavior, and helping them gain deeper insight into their concerns (Jarvis et al., 2020). This practice is evidence based, and studies show that counselors receiving as little as one hour of training on the CFI improved their ability to work with culturally diverse clients (Jarvis et al., 2020).

Factors that Impact Assessment Choice

Selecting the correct psychological assessments requires careful consideration of the client's individual context. Factors such as the client's academic/educational background, career stage, personal development, and social experiences all play critical roles in shaping how assessments are chosen, administered, and interpreted (Cohen et al., 2022).

Academic/Educational Development

A client's level of education and academic history can greatly influence test performance, especially on standardized cognitive or aptitude assessments (Dana, 2005). For example, a client with limited education or incomplete schooling may score lower on academic-based assessments, not because of a lack of intelligence, but due to unfamiliarity with the testing format or language (Cohen et al., 2022). According to Dana, assessments that do not account for potential educational disparities pose a risk of misdiagnosing learning difficulties or underestimating a client's potential (2005).

Career Development

According to the Theory of Work Adjustment (TWA), a good fit between an individual's needs and the work environment predicts job satisfaction and tenure (Brown & Lent, 2021).

Therefore, assessments should align with the client's vocational goals, strengths, limitations, and perceived barriers to employment (Brown & Lent, 2021). However, counselors should be cautious not to rely on career tests that don't take a multicultural approach, as these may carry cultural and socioeconomic biases that do not reflect the diverse pathways clients take to achieve professional fulfillment (Brown & Lent, 2021).

Personal Development

A client's emotional maturity, self-perception, and cognitive ability also affect how they understand and respond to assessments (APA, 2020). For example, clients experiencing trauma, anxiety, low self-esteem, or depressive symptoms may respond differently to personality measures or self-report inventories (APA, 2020). The American Psychological Association (APA, 2020) recommends that counselors consider a client's emotional readiness and psychological functioning when selecting and administering assessments.

Social and Cultural Development

Social and cultural development, including family relationships and dynamics, relationships, and community influences have a significant impact on how individuals understand and respond to psychological assessment (Ridley et al., 2021). Social context may shape a client's willingness to disclose personal information, trust in the assessment process, and interpretation of test content (Cohen et al., 2022). Assessments must be interpreted under the lens of social realities, including systemic inequality, discrimination, and cultural norms (Ridley et al., 2021). For example, clients from collectivist cultures may prioritize group harmony and devalue individual achievement or emotion expression (Sue et al., 2012). In such cases, assessments focused on individual achievement or self-enhancement may not align with the

client's social and cultural values and beliefs. Counselors should consider culturally appropriate assessments or use standardized measures with culturally appropriate methods (Sue et al., 2012).

Conclusion

Psychological assessment is an essential part of the counseling process that ethical application to ensure fairness and accuracy for all clients. This paper has examined several key ethical issues, such as informed consent, multicultural and diversity, confidentiality, and appropriate use of tests and results. Strategies for avoiding ethical issues were discussed, along with guidance on how counselors can accurately assess behaviors rooted in cultural and subcultural contexts. Additionally, this paper explored how a client's academic, career, personal, and social development will influence the selection of appropriate assessment tools by a counselor. Throughout the discussion, the ACA Code of Ethics, specifically Section E, provided foundational guidelines for ethical assessment practices. By integrating cultural awareness, developmental understanding, and ethical responsibility, counselors can conduct assessments that are culturally appropriate and serve their clients effectively.

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Reflection 08/07/2026

When I wrote this paper over a year ago, my understanding of psychological assessments was primarily based on what I had learned through coursework and reading. I understood the importance of informed consent, confidentiality, cultural considerations, and using assessments appropriately, but I had very little practical experience applying these principles with actual clients. Since writing this paper, my perspective has become more practical and nuanced.

During my clinical experience, I have administered many PHQ-9 and GAD-7 assessments, as well as completed numerous suicide risk assessments. While these are relatively straightforward compared to more comprehensive psychological testing, using them repeatedly has helped me understand the responsibility that comes with assessment. I have learned that an assessment is not simply about obtaining a score. The results need to be considered alongside the client's presentation, history, current circumstances, and other information gathered during counseling. This connects directly to my original understanding that assessment results should be interpreted within the broader context of the individual rather than viewed in isolation.

My experience with suicide risk assessments has also changed how I view the ethical importance of assessment. When an assessment indicates potential risk, the results can directly influence clinical decision-making and safety planning. This has made the concepts of appropriate interpretation and responsible use of assessment results feel much more real than they did when I wrote this paper.

I still have limited experience with psychological assessment overall, particularly with more comprehensive standardized testing. However, I feel much more confident than I did a year ago in understanding the purpose of assessment and recognizing that ethical assessment requires more than simply administering a measure correctly. My view has shifted from seeing

assessment primarily as a clinical tool to seeing it as a responsibility that requires careful judgment, context, and consideration of the individual client.